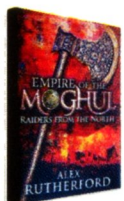


Mughal EMBERS

The Central Asian warlord who conquered Hindustan comes alive in a historical thriller



EMPIRE OF THE MOGHUL: RAIDERS FROM THE NORTH
by ALEX RUTHERFORD
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| By Dilip Bobb |

Revisiting history can be risky, as the upheaval over Jaswant Singh's portrayal of Jinnah exemplifies. There is, however, a safer option: historical epic as romantic drama. Bollywood has done this with success (*Mughal-e-Azam* to *Jodhaa Akbar*) and now Alex Rutherford takes similar artistic licence with his new book on Babur, founder of one of history's richest, most powerful dynasties. *Empire of the Moghul* is classified by the publishers as fiction/historical, which means it straddles two literary stools. Rutherford does not distort history, he merely dramatises it by using a racy style, adding new characters, fleshing out others, including the protagonist and his many wives, and using drama and suspense to trace Babur's rise from a warlord from Ferghana, a tiny kingdom in Central Asia to conqueror of the prize coveted by every king from Alexander to Genghis Khan: Hindustan.

However, any biography of Babur (1483-1530) has to compete with the one that has the most credibility, *Baburnama*, his own memoirs and the first autobiography in Islamic literature, which set down, in his words, "all that is good or bad I have seen of father, kinsman or stranger...". Babur's father died when he was 12 years old and from that tender age, his life was a series of

battles, conspiracies, traitorous relatives, blood feuds, defeats and conquests, and truly epic challenges. What makes Rutherford's task easier is that chunks of the original *Baburnama* were lost, leaving significant gaps. He fills these using literary imagination, skilful writing, plenty of colour, conversations and characterisation but without cheating on historical accuracy.

The author retraces more than history. He visits every place important to Babur's story to get a feel for background and colour, from his ancestral kingdom of Ferghana, now in Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan, to the trail of Babur's failed campaigns and bloody battles in Samarkand, Kabul and down through the Khyber Pass to the plains of northern India and the cities he spent the most time in, Delhi and Agra. Zahiruddin Muhammad Babur Badshah Ghazi was a born warrior and visionary who's ambition was fuelled by his ancestors, Genghis Khan, from his mother's side and Timur (Timur the Lame), both warrior-kings whose conquests were unrivalled at the time. How he countered the plots against his life, betrayals, failed marriages, tribal rivalries, rampaging armies and ruthless enemies to become the ruler of India is a classic superhero adventure story. Rutherford adds the necessary ingredients to the royal epic, canny advisers, lion-hearted generals, a supportive mother and a close friend he can confide in to turn it into a blockbuster novel.

For all his vision, courage and greatness, Babur's place in history is hardly in keeping with his status as founder of one of the world's greatest dynasties. Indeed, the most enlightened and celebrated period of the Moghul (or Mughal) empire was during Babur's grandson Akbar's era and it is Shah Jahan's buildings, notably Red Fort and the Taj Mahal, which remain the dynasty's enduring legacies. Babur built the Babri Masjid which added an infamous chapter to Indian history. Babur, in fact, never got accustomed to India's heat and dust and returned to Kabul and was buried there. His modest grave was neglected and overlooked, much like his place in history, and only recently has it been restored by UNESCO. Rutherford does much the same by resurrecting Babur's legacy and giving it a new and dramatic lease of literary life. ■

SAURABH SINGH

